

Spanish A1 — Week 5 Student Overview

Crescere | Beginner Spanish | Week 5

Theme: Tener, Age, and Family

What You Will Learn This Week

Week 5 introduces *tener* — to have. It is the third essential Spanish verb after *ser* and *estar*, and it works differently than you might expect.

In Spanish, age is something you **have**, not something you **are**. Hunger, thirst, cold, and sleepiness are also things you have. This week you will add *tener* to your toolkit and use it to describe yourself and the people around you.

You will also learn a core set of family vocabulary and how to combine *tener + ser + estar + regular verbs* to give a real description of someone.

What You Will Be Able to Say by the End of Week 5

By the end of Session 10, you should be able to describe your family or the people closest to you:

Tengo una hermana y un hermano. Mi hermana se llama Ana — tiene treinta y ocho años. Es médica y trabaja en un hospital en Valencia. Está muy ocupada pero es muy paciente. Mi hermano tiene cuarenta y dos años. Tiene dos hijos. Vive en el extranjero y trabaja en tecnología. Mis padres tienen setenta años y están jubilados. Viven en el pueblo donde nacimos.

And answer spontaneously:

- ¿Cuántos años tienes? — Tengo [X] años.
- ¿Tienes hermanos? — Sí, tengo [X]. / No, soy hijo/a único/a.
- ¿Cuántos años tiene tu madre? — Tiene [X] años.

Tener — The Essential Conjugation

Subject	Tener
yo	tengo
tú	tienes
él / ella / usted	tiene
nosotros/as	tenemos
vosotros/as	tenéis
ellos / ellas / ustedes	tienen

The only irregular form is yo: tengo. All other forms follow the regular -er pattern you already know. After this week, *tengo* will be as automatic as *soy* and *estoy*.

Age in Spanish

This surprises almost every beginner:

- English: I **am** thirty.
- Spanish: **Tengo** treinta años. (I **have** thirty years.)

Soy treinta años is wrong in Spanish. Age always uses *tener*. This parallels the French pattern (*J'ai trente ans*) — the same logic.

Tener Expressions — Things You Have

Spanish uses *tener* where English uses "to be" for physical feelings:

Spanish	English
Tengo hambre.	I'm hungry.
Tengo sed.	I'm thirsty.
Tengo sueño.	I'm sleepy.
Tengo frío.	I'm cold.
Tengo razón.	I'm right.

The key: **do not use *estar* for these**. *Estoy hambre* is incorrect. *Tengo hambre* — you have hunger.

Possessives: Mi, Tu, Su

To describe your family you need three possessive words:

Spanish	Meaning	Singular	Plural
mi / mis	my	<i>mi hermano</i>	<i>mis hermanos</i>
tu / tus	your	<i>tu madre</i>	<i>tus padres</i>
su / sus	his / her / their	<i>su hijo</i>	<i>sus hijos</i>

Important: Possessives agree with the *noun*, not with you. Whether you are male or female, you say *mi hermana* for your sister and *mis hermanas* for your sisters.

What to Practice Between Sessions

After Session 9 — before Session 10:

1. **Say the tener conjugation from memory.** *Tengo, tienes, tiene, tenemos, tenéis, tienen*. Especially *tengo* — say it until it is automatic.
2. **Write your age and 3 family sentences.** *Tengo X años. Tengo [X] hermanos. Mi hermano tiene [X] años.*
3. **Say them out loud.** No notes on the third try.

After Session 10 — before Session 11:

1. **Write your family description paragraph.** 5–7 sentences. Mix *tener*, *ser*, *estar*, and at least one regular verb.
2. **Say it without notes.** Third try with no looking.
3. **Add someone outside family.** 2–3 sentences describing a close friend or colleague using the same combination of verbs.

Vocabulary to Know Before Week 6

See the full list in your Week 5 Vocabulary Reference. The most important items for Session 11 are:

- All six forms of *tener* — especially *tengo*, *tiene*, *tienen*
- Age structure: *tengo/tiene [X] años*
- 8 family members with *mi/mis* in front
- 3 *tener* expressions (*hambre*, *sed*, *sueño* at minimum)
- The pattern: *tener* (age/possession/expressions) + *ser* (identity/origin) + *estar* (state) in the same paragraph

Crescere — Spanish A1 Week 5 / Questions? Contact your instructor.